Peer critique

Using criteria to improve work

Use peer critique when students understand the content and criteria well enough to offer accurate, useful feedback. Teach the feedback routine before exchanging work.

How to do it well

1 Establish the culture. Explain that critique is a learning tool and agree the norm: kind, specific and helpful.

2 Make quality visible. Clarify the criteria and compare model, near-miss and weak feedback comments.

3 Model SPARK live. Use anonymous work to demonstrate how a precise observation becomes a referenced, actionable suggestion.

4 Rehearse before exchange. Co-construct comments, evaluate examples and use sentence stems until pupils can distinguish strong from vague feedback.

5 Give and receive feedback. Begin with a genuine strength, then identify one high-impact improvement connected to the criteria.

6 Act and close the loop. The recipient decides how to use the comment, revises the work and explains the change; the teacher samples quality and accuracy.

What this sounds like

“Identify one success against the criterion. Then pinpoint one place to improve and suggest an action. The writer will decide how to use it and explain the change.”

Classroom example. In Art, pupils first compare useful and vague critique against one criterion. They then give a precise observation and an actionable suggestion on a partner’s work. The recipient evaluates the suggestion, revises the selected feature and explains the change. The teacher samples whether comments are accurate as well as respectful.

Top tips that make the technique work

Use SPARK. Comments should be Specific, Prescriptive, Actionable, Referenced to a criterion and Kind.

Model a weak comment too. Comparing “good work” with a precise suggestion helps students see what usefulness means.

Start with one criterion. Narrow the demand before expecting peers to judge an entire piece.

Keep responsibility with the recipient. Students should evaluate the comment, make a justified change and explain it.

Sample accuracy. Peer feedback does not replace teacher expertise when a misconception is difficult to diagnose.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Teach the criteria and model useful comments.	Exchanging work before students know the standard.
Require the recipient to act.	Personal preferences or vague praise presented as critique.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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